Chapter 6 – Buddhism and the Regrets of Ashoka

"If I were asked under what sky the human mind has most fully developed some of its choicest gifts, has most deeply pondered on the greatest problems of life, and has found solutions, I should point to India."

(Max Mueller, *India: What it Can Teach Us*)

Like his grandfather, Chandragupta Maurya, Emperor Ashoka was brought up to follow the Hindu way of life. He read the Vedic texts, schooled his own children in the ceremonies of ancient teachings, and married many women as was the custom of his family and his people. Spiritual beliefs and customs were not something that weighed heavily on the mind of an emperor quick to his sword until a life-changing battle filled him with remorse. It was the Conquest of the Kalingas that forever altered the heart of Emperor Ashoka and the spiritual landscape of India itself.

The Kingdom of Kalinga was located at the southeastern edge of modern India, along the Bay of Bengal. In every direction except east, Kalinga was surrounded by Ashoka's Mauryan Empire and therefore under constant political pressure to submit to the power of the emperor. Since the establishment of the empire by Chandragupta Maurya himself, the purpose of rule was to integrate every corner of the subcontinent under the centralized authority of the emperors, and so, Ashoka was compelled to conquer it. Therefore, soon after he had been recognized as Emperor following the retirement of his father, Ashoka looked to Kalinga and prepared to wage war.

An estimated 150,000 Kalinga warriors and 100,000 Maurya warriors were killed in what has been documented as one of the world's most fierce and bloody clashes. The Daya River, which ran near the battlefield, is said to have been stained red with the blood of the slain soldiers. Of those Kalinga who survived the massacre, most were deported from their land of birth at the command of Emperor Ashoka. The emperor himself had these reports carved over the surfaces of large boulders to commemorate his achievements–and also to document his great lament over having caused such suffering in the name of imperialism. It had indeed been a life-changing experience not only for those subjugated to the Mauryan Empire